POLAR WINDOW

A lifecycle planner for CLPS lunar deliveries, from launch to return, with the uncertainty and source of every number

Submission report for the 2026 challenge *CLPS Lunar Mission Browser*. Response times, test counts and screens were measured on commit `43a1815` of branch `visual-refresh` (4 October 2026). An engine check run on another date says so.

Abstract

NASA's Commercial Lunar Payload Services (CLPS) programme buys the delivery of science payloads to the Moon from commercial providers. Planning one delivery draws on separate tools for launch design, weather, trajectory, radiation, communications and recovery, each with its own conventions. This report describes POLAR WINDOW, an open planner that follows one CLPS delivery through six sections: readiness, launch, trip, landing, contact with Earth and return. Every number it serves states its source, its margin or the reason it has none. It also carries the age of any live input. No section returns a verdict or a combined score. The engines are checked against the public record of flown missions. The references are NASA's reconstructed trajectories of four CLPS landers, the reconstructed descents of the three that landed, their published liftoff times and NOAA's list of solar particle events. Measured lunar radiation doses and the landing point of the OSIRIS-REx capsule complete the set. Skylines are cast over NASA terrain models at the south pole and at every mission target that a model covers. Touchdown instants agree with NASA's descent reconstructions within one second. Designed at the direction each vehicle climbed, the launch instants of the three flown Falcon 9 missions fall within one minute of the published liftoffs. One day of propagation from a reconstructed state stays within one kilometre in all but one case. Unmet planned tolerances are reported with their measured values. When the climb direction is not known in advance, a designed launch instant misses by about 16 to 18 minutes. The default NRLMSIS 2.1 atmosphere lands the capsule within 6.6 kilometres of the measured touchdown, satisfying the 10 kilometre plan tolerance. It was chosen by a rule written after both landing results were known, using mesospheric measurements only partly independent of the models. Multi-year weather reforecasts show positive Brier skill at Vandenberg but fail on reliability, while Cape Canaveral lacks sufficient events, leaving wind shares marked as not checked. Belt fluences agree with SPENVIS within five percent on five of seven belt passages, and two miss on protons. Link budgets and the return trajectory from the Moon remain unbuilt because their inputs are not public.

1 Introduction

NASA's Commercial Lunar Payload Services (CLPS) programme buys the delivery of science payloads to the Moon from commercial providers [1]. Four CLPS landers have flown: Peregrine Mission One, IM-1, Blue Ghost Mission 1 and IM-2. Their reconstructed trajectories are public in NASA's SPICE archive [2]. The 2026 NASA Space Apps challenge *CLPS Lunar Mission Browser* asks for a tool to compare landing sites and dates [3]. The tool is meant for planners, educators and the public, and it should show the Sun and Earth against the local horizon.

The first version of POLAR WINDOW answered one question. At a south-polar site and over chosen dates, it reported how long the Sun and Earth stay above the site's own skyline. A delivery raises many more questions. A project manager must know when the vehicle can leave the pad and whether the weather rules allow it. The trip passes through sunlight, shadow and the radiation belts. After landing, the team needs the hours in which a ground station can hear the lander. The launch vehicle's booster comes back to a landing zone on land or at sea. Each

payload must also be built, tested and delivered on time. Each answer comes from a different tool and data source, and each tool states its assumptions in its own way.

This report describes the extension of POLAR WINDOW into a planner that follows one CLPS delivery through six sections: *Ready*, *Launch*, *Trip*, *Landing*, *Contact* and *Return*. The screens label the Landing section *Surface*, since it answers for the time on the surface after landing. The work makes four contributions.

1. A single contract for every number. Each value states its provenance: computed, published, entered by a named person, or assumed. It carries a margin (a ±, a range or a multiplicative factor) or the reason it has none. It also carries the age of any live input. No section returns a verdict, a readiness percentage or a combined score.
2. Trajectory, launch, radiation and entry engines checked against flown missions. The references are NASA's reconstructions of the four CLPS trips, of the three descents that reached the surface, and the measured landing of the OSIRIS-REx sample capsule.
3. A process design that separates network access, long computations and request handling. Every stored answer records the inputs and engine versions it came from. Section 5.10 measures its response times and its job queue under load.
4. A disclosure of every planned acceptance tolerance that the engines do not meet, with the measured value beside it.

The evaluation is bounded by public data. Only four CLPS trips have reconstructions, and none of the planned missions publishes a trajectory, a radio link budget or a return state. The engines are therefore checked on the flown cases, and the planned missions receive designed answers labelled as such. Of the two external references named in the plan, the General Mission Analysis Tool (GMAT) could not be run. The SPENVIS web service has no programming interface, so seven belt passages were run in it by hand. Section 5 gives that comparison and states what replaced GMAT.

2 Related work

Illumination and Earth visibility at the lunar poles. Polar lighting has been mapped from Lunar Orbiter Laser Altimeter (LOLA) topography [4] by casting horizons and averaging Sun visibility over years [5]. Later work located persistently illuminated regions in camera images [6] and in higher-resolution terrain models [7]. Away from the poles, LOLA's altimetry merged with stereo images from the SELENE Terrain Camera gives the SLDEM2015 model between 60° S and 60° N [8]. These studies produce fractions over long periods on a fixed grid. They answer where the light is on average, not what happens at one landing point over one mission's dates. They also report no timing uncertainty per crossing. The surface engine of POLAR WINDOW computes the Sun and Earth from the Navigation and Ancillary Information Facility's SPICE system [9, 10] with the DE440 ephemeris [11]. It reports each duration with a margin derived from the terrain's vertical error.

Trajectory and launch design. High-fidelity mission design is available in open tools such as GMAT, which has a documented verification programme [12]. Its building blocks are standard. They include Lambert solvers for the initial transfer [13], numerical integration under point-mass and harmonic gravity [14], and lunar gravity fields from GRAIL [15]. These tools require a scripted mission and an analyst. They do not read NASA's CLPS reconstructions or relate a launch day to the lighting rule at the landing site. They also do not label an input as published or assumed. POLAR WINDOW does not compete with them on fidelity. It connects a small, checked subset of their methods to the landing site, the pad and the reconstructions.

Launch weather and forecast verification. Launch weather criteria are published per vehicle as rule sets. The Falcon 9 rules, for example, limit the wind at 162 ft and lightning near

the pad [16]. Ensemble systems such as the Global Ensemble Forecast System (GEFS) give a sample of possible weather [17]. Lightning is observed from orbit by the Geostationary Lightning Mapper (GLM) [18, 19], and long wind records come from the MERRA-2 reanalysis [20]. The standard score for a probability forecast is the Brier score [21]. Public presentations of launch weather usually give one chance of a rule being broken. They rarely state the sample behind it or whether that chance has been checked against observations.

Radiation screening. Trapped belt fluxes are commonly taken from the AE8 and AP8 models [22, 23]. The IRBEM library[1] implements them, and SpacePy exposes them in Python [24]. Galactic cosmic rays (GCR) can be modelled with one solar modulation parameter [25]. Measured doses exist in lunar orbit from CRaTER [26] and on the far-side surface from Chang'e-4 [27]. Large solar particle events are described by published spectra [28]. Engineering tools such as OLTARIS compute dose behind shielding once a trajectory and a geometry are known [29]. They need an account and a finished design, so they do not serve early screening of several candidate trips.

Contact planning. The Deep Space Network (DSN) publishes each antenna's horizon mask and link parameters [30]. Delay-tolerant networks route messages over scheduled contacts with contact graph routing [31]. Neither source combines a station's mask with the terrain around a polar lander, which decides whether Earth is visible at all.

Gap. Each area has mature tools, but each answers one phase with its own conventions. None carries the provenance and uncertainty of a number from the pad to the landing site and back. POLAR WINDOW keeps both attached to every number across the six phases of a delivery. Its engines are deliberately simpler than the specialist tools above. Designed values are labelled as designed, and the radiation answers name the tools in which a design must be confirmed.

3 System design

3.1 Processes and data flow

The system is one Python code base run as three long-lived processes over PostgreSQL and Redis (fig. 1). The *API* process answers requests from the browser and from the agents. It reads stored answers and feed snapshots, and it never waits for a long computation. The *compute worker* runs trajectory, launch-calendar and contact jobs. The *feeds worker* is the only process that reaches external services. It fetches weather, space weather, launch schedules and DSN activity, and it stores each response as a snapshot with its fetch time. An import contract enforces this rule in code. No module in the API, the services, the agents or the numerical core can import the feed package.

An answer that takes seconds or minutes to compute is a *job*. Its key is a hash of the job kind, its parameters and the versions of every engine it depends on, called its *closure*. When a stored answer with that key exists, the API returns it at once. Otherwise the API queues a job and returns HTTP status 202 with a job reference, and the page polls until the answer is ready. Workers lease jobs from a PostgreSQL table with row locks that skip rows already taken. Several workers can therefore run without a separate queue service. Each answer is stored as an *assessment* together with its inputs. These are the feed snapshot identifiers, the catalogue versions, the kernel set, the terrain product and any values a person entered. An answer is therefore reused until one of its inputs or engine versions changes. A worker that is stopped hands its job back to the queue without spending one of the job's three attempts. A worker that dies is covered by its lease, which runs out after a minute.

[1] `https://prbem.github.io/IRBEM/`

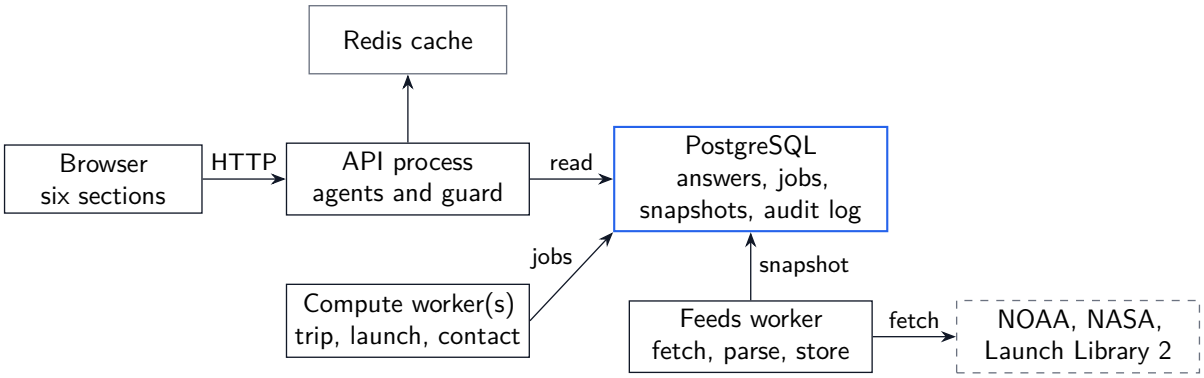


Figure 1: Processes. Only the feeds worker has outbound network access; the API queues work and reads stored answers.

On a server the same processes run as containers. A web server in front serves the built pages and passes requests for the API through, so the browser sees one address. Only that port is open to the outside, and the database, the cache and the API listen on the machine itself. One script, `run_onVM.py`, installs Docker, builds the two images, fetches the data and starts the stack.

3.2 One contract for every number

Every value that leaves the service has one shape, called a *quantity*. It holds the value, the unit, the provenance and exactly one form of margin: a symmetric ±, a low-to-high range, or a multiplicative factor. A value without a margin carries a sentence that says why. A value that cannot be given is null and carries its *missing reason*, for example that a vehicle's limit is not published. A duration cut short by the chosen dates is flagged as a lower bound. Probabilities use a second shape, called a *share*. It holds k of n model runs, an exact binomial interval [32] and a flag stating whether the share has been checked against observations.

Four rules of the project govern these shapes. No section returns a verdict: there is no go or no-go, no readiness percentage, no risk score and no overall chance of launch. Every number states whether it was computed, published, entered or assumed. Every live number shows its age, and past its staleness budget it is replaced by the reason there is no number. Every probability states its sample and its verification status. A schema test and the agents' guard check the first rule (section 4.9).

3.3 Layering, versions and catalogues

The numerical core has no input or output, no clock and no database access. Ten import contracts keep the layers apart. Among them, SPICE is reachable from one module only. Routes reach the domain only through services, and agents reach it only through their tool module. Each engine carries its own version, for example `traj-4` for the trajectory engine, `lw-7` for launch design and `rad-5` for radiation. The surface engine's version did not change for this report's additions: a mission target that gained a terrain model had its stored skyline rebuilt, and the browser's cache key for a site carries the name of its terrain product, so a returning browser fetches the new numbers. A change to one engine invalidates only the answers whose closure contains it.

Static facts live in nine cited catalogues: launch pads, vehicles, ground stations, relays, recovery zones, landing attempts, lessons, risk scales and weather rules. Every record carries its sources and compile date. A value that no source publishes is left empty with its reason and is never filled with a typical figure. The mission list itself holds 20 CLPS deliveries and 64 payloads, each payload with a source address.

3.4 Data

Everything the engines read is public. Table 1 lists the files, 1.2 GB on disk in all. A registry in the code names each one with its address, its size and, where the provider's file is stable, its SHA-256. One command fetches what is missing and resumes an interrupted download. A resumed download is accepted only if the server confirms that the file has not changed since the first part was fetched. The large terrain files are never downloaded whole: a window around each site is read by HTTP range requests. Two archives are left out, the Kennedy field mill record (1.5 TB) and the GLM thunder-hour record (77 GB). The month-by-hour thunder climatology built from the second is kept in the repository. Live inputs are not files. The feeds worker fetches them on a schedule: GEFS, HRRR and GFS-Wave forecasts, National Weather Service point forecasts and alerts, buoy reports, space weather from NOAA and NASA's DONKI, DSN Now, launch schedules from Launch Library 2 and the orbiters' ephemerides from JPL Horizons.

Table 1: The data on disk, by use. Sizes are those of the files as stored.

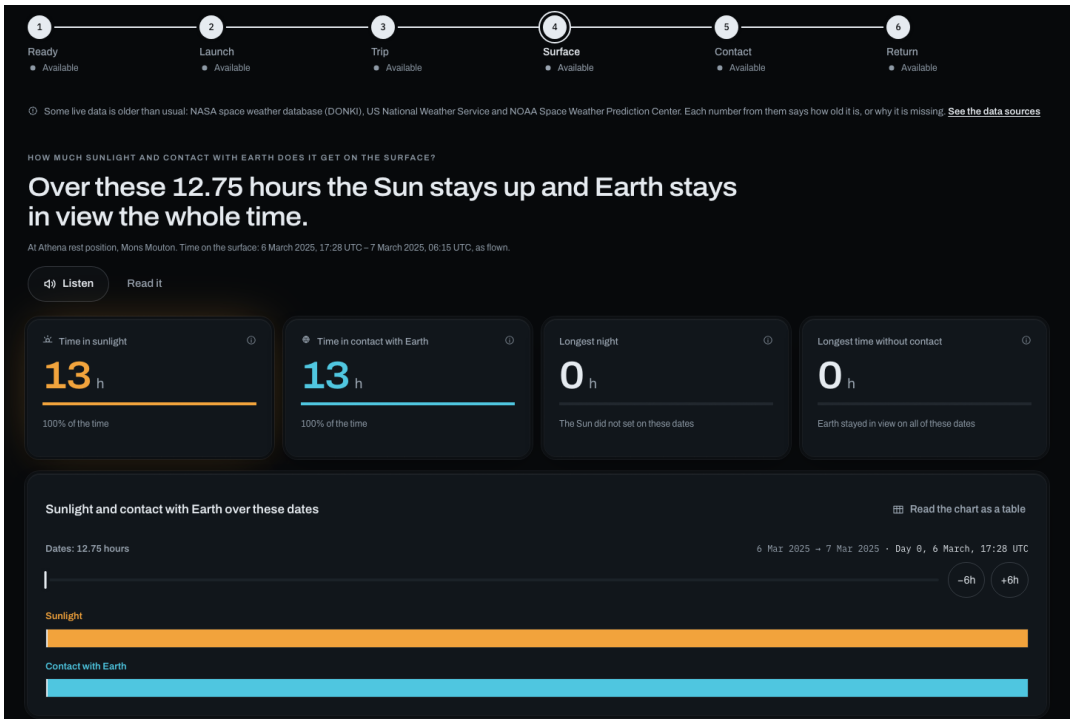
Data	Used for	Size
SPICE kernels from NAIF: DE440, lunar orientation and frames, Earth orientation, DSN stations [10, 11]	Positions of the Sun, Earth and Moon; pads and ground stations	168 MB
LOLA polar models [4]: 80 m whole, 20 m windows at each polar site, a 60 m window at Schrödinger	Skylines south of 60° S	340 MB
SLDEM2015 windows [8] at Mare Crisium, Sinus Viscositatis and Reiner Gamma	Skylines of mission targets between 60° S and 60° N	36 MB
LROC stereo models at 3 and 4 m [33] and LOLA's 5 m model	Rover-to-lander line of sight	36 MB
GRAIL gravity field GRGM1200A [15]	The Moon's field on the trip and in lunar orbit	98 MB
OMNI hourly solar and geomagnetic indices	Air density for entry; history of solar events	197 MB
DSN handbook module 301 and its horizon masks [30]	When a station can hear the lander	4 MB
CLPS SPICE archive [2]: four cruises, three descents, three landing sites, frames	Flown trips; checks of the trip, launch and landing engines	50 MB
LRO reconstructed orbit; Goldstone radar terrain; OSIRIS-REx capsule; SABER and lidar air	Checks of the lunar orbit, the skylines and the capsule entry	163 MB
GEFS and HRRR winds at the pads, reduced; station winds	Checks of the launch weather shares	12 MB
Map tiles, built locally from the terrain	The maps	138 MB

4 Methods by mission section

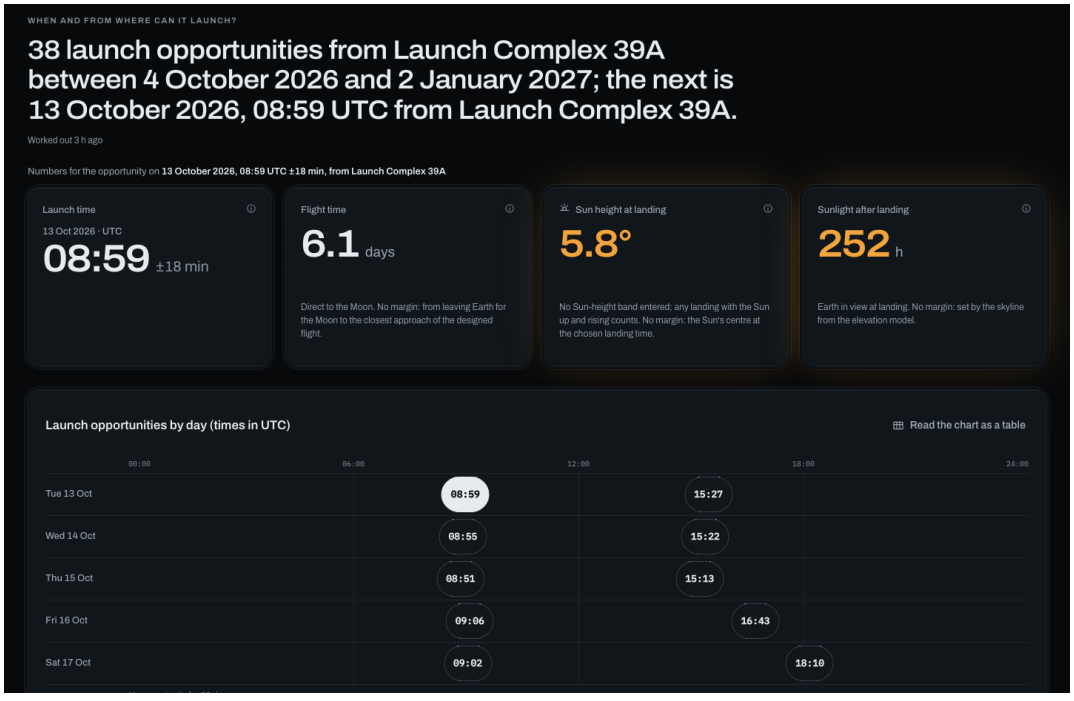
Table 2 lists the six sections, the question each one answers and the reference against which its engine is checked. The subsections below describe the engines in the order of a delivery. Figure 2 shows two sections as the project manager sees them. Each number carries its margin, or a sentence stating why it has none.

4.1 Landing: the Sun and Earth above the local skyline

South of 80° S, terrain comes from the LOLA polar elevation models at 20 m (to 20 km from the site) and 80 m (to 50 km). A mission target elsewhere takes a 55 km window of the model that



(a) IM-2's Landing section, labelled *Surface*: the six steps above its four numbers and the chart they are read from.



(b) Griffin-1's Launch section: the next liftoff carries the larger held-out miss, ±18 min.

Figure 2: Two screens at commit `43a1815`, 1440 pixels wide, dark theme, cropped.

Table 2: The six mission sections and the checks behind them.

Section	Question answered	Engine checked against
Ready	What is built, tested and delivered, and what is blocked?	State rules and the hash-chained audit log (tests)
Launch	When can the vehicle leave the pad for a landing the lighting allows?	Flown liftoffs of IM-1, IM-2 and Blue Ghost 1
Launch weather	Which published weather rule would be broken, in how many model runs?	One year of station observations at the Cape
Trip	Where is the spacecraft, when is it in shadow, what radiation does it meet?	NASA reconstructions of four CLPS trips and LRO; SPENVIS; NOAA's event list
Landing	How long are the Sun and Earth above the site's skyline?	NASA's descent reconstructions of three landers; Blue Ghost 1's reported end; golden fixtures
Contact	When can a ground station hear the lander, and how long must a message wait?	DSN masks and SPICE station kernels (tests); JPL Horizons; GDAL
Return	Where does the booster or a capsule come down, in what sea?	OSIRIS-REx's measured landing point

covers it. Between 60° S and 80° S that is LOLA's 60 m polar model. Between 60° S and 60° N it is SLDEM2015 [8], at 512 pixels per degree, about 59 m. A target north of 60° N, or one whose window is not on disk, is computed against a smooth sphere, and every answer for it says so. Rays are cast on 1,440 bearings with the Moon's curvature removed, giving the elevation of the skyline in every direction. The Sun and Earth come from SPICE in the `MOON_ME` frame with light-time and stellar aberration corrections. A body is *up* when its centre clears the skyline at its azimuth. Each skyline crossing is located by bisection between time samples, so its time is not rounded to the step. Four durations follow over the chosen dates. The screens name them time in sunlight, time in contact with Earth, the longest night and the longest time without contact. Each duration carries a ± from the terrain's vertical error divided by the rate at which the body crosses the skyline. That error is one figure per product: 2 m for the 20 m model, 4 m for the 60 and 80 m models and 3.5 m for SLDEM2015. A crossing too shallow to time is reported as *grazing* instead of receiving a margin.

4.2 Launch: liftoff instants backed out from the landing

Landing rule. A landing time is allowed when the Sun's centre is above the site's skyline and rising, and the Earth is up. The project manager may narrow the Sun elevation to a band. Landing times that satisfy the rule are moved back by the time in lunar orbit and the flight time. The result is the set of days on which the vehicle must leave Earth.

Liftoff instant. For a direct transfer the arrival at the Moon fixes the plane of the parking orbit. The pad must lie in that plane at liftoff. The climb direction then follows from $\sin A = \cos i / \cos \varphi$. Here A is the inertial azimuth, i the parking orbit's inclination and φ the pad's latitude. The angle a climb falls behind a circular orbit started at the pad, called here the *climb constant*, is measured on the vehicle's flown lunar launches. A design then corrects three quantities in the force model until the arrival matches. They are the liftoff time, the coast in the parking orbit before trans-lunar injection (TLI), and the speed that TLI adds. The force model holds the Sun, the Moon as a point mass and the Earth's zonal harmonics J2 to J6. A candidate climb azimuth outside the range's published or assumed limits is refused.

Phasing loops. Blue Ghost 1 flew several long Earth orbits before leaving for the Moon. For such a mission, the design raises the perigee at the first apogee. It then sets the period of the remaining loops and leaves Earth at the last perigee. It corrects liftoff, coast and the three burns in the force model for each launch day and keeps the cheapest loop count.

4.3 Trip: propagation, shadow and correction budget

A flown trip is read from NASA's reconstruction [2]. A designed trip is propagated in the J2000 frame on the barycentric dynamical time scale with an eighth-order Dormand–Prince integrator at a relative tolerance of 10^{-12}. The Sun and Moon are point masses from DE440 [11]. Earth gravity is modelled with EGM2008 [34] to degree and order 8, capturing near-Earth tesseral harmonics. Within ten lunar radii (17,380 km) the Moon's field is the GRAIL model GRGM1200A [15] to degree 50. Solar radiation pressure is off by default, because no lander publishes its area and mass at that point in the flight. Shadow stretches come from conical Earth and Moon shadows with the overlap of the two discs [14], and each edge is bisected.

The correction budget is worked out for two sets of errors. The first is an assumed error model. In the second, the errors at departure come from the injection accuracy printed in the launch vehicle's user guide. The Falcon 9 guide prints rows for low Earth orbit and geosynchronous transfer orbit only, with none for trans-lunar injection, so its geosynchronous row serves as a proxy. Errors at departure, in orbit knowledge and in each burn (the model of Gates [35]) are pushed through the trajectory in two ways. The linear method uses state transition matrices of each stretch. The Monte Carlo method flies seeded runs through the full force model. In each run, every correction burn aims the run's own estimated state at the planned arrival. The answer reports the 95th and 99th percentiles of the total correction and labels them a budget for the errors named, which are assumed except where the launch vehicle's guide publishes them.

4.4 Trip: radiation screening

Belt fluence along the trajectory comes from AE8 and AP8 [22, 23] through IRBEM in SpacePy [24], with a factor of two on every value. IRBEM evaluates AP8 with the GSFC 12/66 magnetic field model at epoch 1970, preserving the original model calibration. The South Atlantic Anomaly has drifted west since the maps were made. The engine therefore rotates the point at which a map is read eastward by 0.3° per year since the map's epoch, the convention of ESA's UNILIB library.[2] The cosmic-ray dose is CRaTER's measured rate [26] scaled by the change of the model of Matthiä et al. [25] with solar modulation. The modulation parameter comes from the Oulu neutron monitor. On the surface, Chang'e-4's measured rate [27] is scaled the same way. It is also scaled by the fraction of open sky above the site, taken from the site's own skyline. Solar particle events during a flown trip are listed from NASA's DONKI record. Three past large events give comparison fluences: August 1972 from King's spectrum [28], and October 1989 and October 2003 integrated from GOES proton data. Every radiation answer states that it is screening only and names the tools in which a design must be confirmed.

4.5 Contact: when a station hears the lander

A ground station hears the lander when two conditions hold at once. Earth must be above the lander's skyline, which is the surface engine's existing number. The lander must also be above the station's own horizon mask, taken from the DSN handbook [30] per degree of azimuth. The station positions come from SPICE station kernels. The union over the 14 catalogued DSN antennas is the *time a ground station can hear the lander*. Contacts between nodes, each with its one-way light time, feed an earliest-arrival search over contacts, the simplest exact form of contact graph routing [31]. It yields the longest time a message created on the lander waits before it reaches Earth.

[2] `https://space-env.esa.int/Manuals/UNILIB/v3.02/reference/um510.html`

The plan can be exported in the contact-plan format of the Interplanetary Overlay Network or as CSV. Planned relays (such as Lunar Pathfinder and Altus-1) are placed in the contact graph by sweeping node and phase over a 36×36 grid, reporting ranges of contact durations and store-and-forward wait times. Real lunar orbiters (LRO, Danuri, Chandrayaan-2, and CAPSTONE) are propagated from weekly JPL Horizons ephemerides as SPK type 13 kernels to display geometric overhead passes. For rovers, line-of-sight and first Fresnel zone clearance are computed up to 5 km, reporting clear, blocked, or uncertain states from elevation uncertainties. The terrain is the finest model that covers the whole neighbourhood and the lander's own ground. In order these are the LROC stereo models at 3 and 4 m near Mons Mouton [33], LOLA's 5 m model south of 87.5° S, and the 20 and 80 m polar models. Each carries its own height error: 4.43, 4.12 and 2 m for the first three. A gap in a stereo model stays unknown and is never filled. Link budgets remain uncomputed, because commercial transmitter powers and gains are not public.

4.6 Launch weather

The twelve weather rules of the Falcon 9 fact sheet [16] are stored verbatim as data, each with its unit, height and class. Two are *model* rules, checked against forecast numbers. Two are *proxy* rules, for which a model can only show the ingredients. Eight are *observation* rules, such as lightning within a set distance in the last 30 minutes, for which no forecast probability is given. A model rule is evaluated per run of the 31-member GEFS ensemble [17]. The wind at the rule's height of 162 ft is interpolated on a logarithmic profile between the model's 10 m and 80 m winds. The value is labelled as interpolated.

The result is a share, k of 31 runs, with its exact interval. Single deterministic forecasts from the National Weather Service (NWS) and High-Resolution Rapid Refresh (HRRR) appear alongside the ensemble shares. A disagreement note flags when single models fall on opposite sides of the threshold or differ by more than HRRR's measured error. Beyond the ensemble's range, the answer falls back to month-by-hour climatology. Wind at 50 m comes from NASA POWER, which is based on MERRA-2 [20], and thunder hours come from GLM [19]. The range's official forecast is entered by the project manager with its document link and is never scraped.

4.7 Return: booster zone and capsule entry

The booster's landing type and zone come from the vehicle catalogue and Launch Library 2 landing records. For a planned droneship landing, the zone lies along the designed launch direction. The GFS-Wave forecast there is compared with limits that the team enters, since providers do not publish them. No CLPS mission returns a capsule. The capsule entry model is therefore checked on OSIRIS-REx [36]. It is a point mass with a ballistic coefficient. It falls from the entry interface through the NRLMSIS 2.1 empirical atmosphere [37], driven by the day's solar flux and geomagnetic indices, over a rotating Earth with J2 gravity. When space weather indices are unavailable, it falls back to the 1976 U.S. Standard Atmosphere [38]. It has no lift and no parachutes.

4.8 Ready: readiness, parts, risks and the audit log

Readiness is a state machine per item. Its states are not started, in build, in test, test passed, delivered to the lander provider, integrated, verified on the lander and ready. An item may also be blocked, with a reason, from any state. Every change needs a date and an evidence link, and illegal moves are refused. Parts carry their status and a dependency path to the measurements they serve. Risks use a configurable likelihood and consequence scale and are never multiplied or summed. Every write needs a named session and is recorded in an append-only log in which each entry holds the hash of the previous one. A database trigger rejects updates and deletions of that log. The landing history lists 14 lunar landing attempts as counts with sourced causes,

never as a success probability.

4.9 Agents

Four language-model agents describe a site, rank sites against a stated requirement, write the same facts for three audiences and answer questions. They reach the system only through ten read-only tools, four of which read the mission sections. A section is cut to at most 200 numbers before an agent sees it, and every kept value keeps its margin. A guard checks every number and full date in an answer against that run's tool results. A small whole number is taken as a count only when no unit follows it. With a unit, or as the first number of a range with one ("9 Earth days", "3 to 7 hours"), it is a claim and is checked like any other. It also rejects verdict words such as *go*, *no-go* or *safe*. After one failed repair, the answer is replaced by a summary built only from measured values.

5 Evaluation

5.1 Setup and choice of references

The response times, test counts and screens were measured with the codebase at commit `43a1815`, and the engine checks were run again on it. A check that needs an outside service keeps the date on which it was run. The machine was an Apple M3 with eight cores and 8 GB of memory. The software was macOS 27.0, Python 3.12.14, PostgreSQL 16.15 and Redis 8.10.2. Every table below is printed by a script or a `make` target listed in appendix A. The references were chosen because they are the only public cases of each kind. NASA's reconstructions cover the four flown CLPS trips, and the Lunar Reconnaissance Orbiter (LRO) adds a well-tracked lunar orbit. OSIRIS-REx is the only recent capsule with both a published entry state and a measured landing point [39, 40]. The plan also named GMAT for the propagator and SPENVIS for the belts. An installation attempt of GMAT R2026a was conducted on this ARM64 macOS host. The distribution requires x86-64 binary translation, and its installer archive could not be retrieved within practical network limits. Closed-form analytic tests replace it. SPENVIS [41] was run by hand, in its web forms, on seven belt passages, and NASA's own AE8/AP8 code gives a second comparison.

5.2 Landing: the Sun and Earth at the flown landers

Each flown lander's published LROC landing point was used as it stands, with its published surface dates. Nothing was tuned to these events. Blue Ghost 1 landed at 18.56° N, where the skyline now comes from SLDEM2015 and stands 0.65° high to the west. Its computed sunset falls on 16 March 2025 at 18:50 UTC ±32 min, the date on which NASA reports that the mission ended. On a smooth sphere, as the site was computed before it had terrain, the sunset was 20:10 UTC. A golden test pins the date. IM-1 and IM-2 both ended while the Sun and Earth were still up at their sites. IM-1's next computed sunset is 2 March 2024 at 14:01 UTC ±28 min, with 83 % of the surrounding terrain inside the elevation model. IM-2's is 19 March 2025 at 19:17 UTC ±34 min. No cause is claimed for either end. The comparison shows that lighting geometry alone does not predict when a mission ends, and the product does not claim that it does.

NASA's SPICE archive also holds each lander's reconstructed descent and its landing site [2]. Table 3 compares them with the mission records. The landing instant in each record is the end of the descent reconstruction, to the second. Before this check IM-1's record held the day only, and IM-2's a press release's "approximately". The archive's landing sites lie within 80 m of the published LROC coordinates, and IM-1's are published to two decimals. At each touchdown the engine's elevations of the Sun and Earth agree with a direct SPICE calculation from the landing site within 0.00003°, against a tolerance of 0.01°.

Four mission targets lie outside the polar models and were computed on a smooth sphere

Table 3: Three touchdowns against NASA's descent reconstructions and landing sites.

Mission	Touchdown (UTC)	Site difference (m)	Sun elevation	Earth elevation
IM-1	2024-02-22 23:23:44	79.2	10.48°	15.43°
IM-2	2025-03-06 17:28:43	0.3	2.46°	11.19°
Blue Ghost 1	2025-03-02 08:34:54	10.4	3.43°	25.73°

until this version. Table 4 gives the terrain each now has. The highest point of each skyline is two to three degrees. At these latitudes the Sun climbs far above that, so the terrain acts at each sunrise and sunset. Blue Ghost 1's sunset moved by 80 minutes. The windows are 55 km around each target, read by range requests: 41 MB in all, from files of 1.4 to 1.9 GB each.

Table 4: Terrain for the four mission targets outside 80° S.

Mission	Target	Model	Spacing	Height error	Highest skyline
Blue Ghost 1	18.56° N, 61.81° E	SLDEM2015	59 m	3.5 m	2.41°
Peregrine	35.25° N, 319.01° E	SLDEM2015	59 m	3.5 m	2.24°
IM-3	7.39° N, 301.04° E	SLDEM2015	59 m	3.5 m	2.67°
APEX-1	74.73° S, 132.93° E	LOLA, 60 m	60 m	4.0 m	2.65°

Blue Ghost 1's target is its landing point. The other three are the centres of named features, since no landing point is published, and the screens say so.

At the pole the answer depends on metres of terrain. Table 5 gives the four numbers at three contrasting candidate sites over a reference window of 708.75 h from 14 March 2027. At Connecting Ridge the Sun's centre stays between $-1.61°$ and $-0.70°$ all month, yet the site is lit in 81 % of the samples (fig. 3). The site stands 1,957.5 m above the reference sphere, and its skyline has a mean elevation of $-2.37°$ and a highest point of $-0.06°$.

Table 5: The four numbers at three candidate sites, in hours, 14 March 2027 plus 708.75 h.

Site	Sunlight	Contact with Earth	Longest night	Longest without contact
Connecting Ridge	574.4 ± 17.1	430.3 ± 5.3	121.6 ± 17.1	278.5 ± 5.3
Malapert massif	394.2 ± 7.3	570.6 ± 7.6	≥ 287.8	138.1 ± 7.6
Faustini rim	103.1 ± 24.0	278.6 ± 33.9	605.7, grazing	430.2, grazing

$\geq$: a lower bound cut short by the window. Grazing: the crossing is too shallow to time, so no margin is given.

5.3 Propagator and shadows against NASA's reconstructions

The acceleration implied by each reconstruction was compared every 10 minutes with the force model's. Where they differ by more than 1×10^{-5} m/s^2, the spacecraft was firing thrusters. A *quiet stretch* is a run below that threshold, less 30 minutes at each end. From the start of a quiet stretch, the reconstructed state was propagated and compared with the reconstruction 24 or 72 hours later. Nothing was fitted. Table 6 gives the result.

The plan's tolerances were 1 km after 24 h and 5 km after 72 h. Every row meets them except IM-2's first cruise day. The model alone gives 4.40 km, so the 1 km plan tolerance is not met. Modelling Earth's gravity with EGM2008 to degree and order 8 reduces this error from 4.62 km by capturing near-Earth tesseral harmonics. Detailed analysis reveals that the remaining residual acceleration is piecewise-constant on a 30-minute barycentric dynamical time grid. It has a median magnitude of 6.71×10^{-7} m/s^2 and points 58° away from the anti-solar direction. Two discrete velocity events appear in NASA's reconstruction at 19:00:00 UTC ($\Delta v = 0.060$ m/s) and 20:45:00 UTC ($\Delta v = 0.133$ m/s). Both events exhibit continuous positions and persistent one-second velocity jumps. They represent velocity changes of 0.060 m/s and 0.133 m/s (small burns or venting). If these two velocity changes were known in advance, applying them drops the

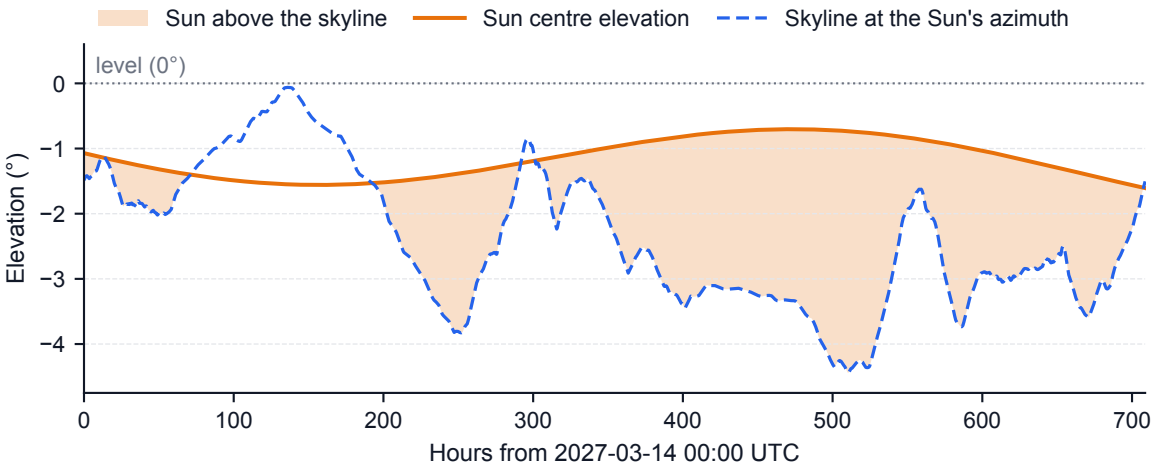


Figure 3: Sun and skyline at Connecting Ridge, 2,836 samples at 900 s. The Sun never rises above level but clears the lowered skyline in 81 % of samples.

Table 6: Position error after propagating a reconstructed state through a quiet stretch.

Reference	Start (UTC)	Where	After	Error (km)	With assumed SRP (km)
Blue Ghost 1	2025-01-15 07:32	cruise	24 h	0.06	0.15
Blue Ghost 1	2025-01-16 07:32	cruise	24 h	0.11	0.07
Blue Ghost 1	2025-01-17 07:32	cruise	24 h	0.11	0.07
Blue Ghost 1	2025-01-15 07:32	cruise	72 h	0.85	1.19
Blue Ghost 1	2025-02-03 13:12	cruise	72 h	1.08	0.62
Blue Ghost 1	2025-02-13 07:02	lunar orbit	9.5 h	0.01	0.02
IM-1	2024-02-19 20:26	cruise	8.5 h	0.64	0.64
IM-1	2024-02-21 02:01	lunar orbit	2.8 h	0.03	0.02
IM-2	2025-02-27 01:51	cruise	24 h	**4.40**	4.22
IM-2	2025-03-01 18:01	cruise	23.3 h	0.65	0.61
IM-2	2025-03-03 13:01	lunar orbit	24 h	0.51	0.50
IM-2	2025-03-04 13:01	lunar orbit	24 h	0.27	0.28
LRO	2025-03-21 01:41	lunar orbit	24 h	0.03	0.03
LRO	2025-03-22 01:41	lunar orbit	24 h	0.07	0.08

SRP: solar radiation pressure with an assumed $C_r A/m$ of 0.01 m^2/kg. The Moon's field is taken to degree 50 in cruise and 100 in lunar orbit. Where no quiet stretch is a day long, the longest one is run to its end. IM-2's first cruise day holds two small burns; it is kept because the plan named it.

24-hour position error from 4.40 km to 1.65 km. Applying the piecewise-constant accelerations measured from the same reconstruction reduces the residual to 8.0 m. This calculation is not a model accuracy result. It demonstrates that the remaining 4.40 km is explained by those unmodelled accelerations.

In lunar orbit, perilune passes across 84 orbits were evaluated under different harmonic truncations of GRGM1200A. A point-mass lunar field leaves false velocity jumps of 0.5 to 1.6 m/s per pass, tripping the maneuver detection threshold of 0.05 m/s. Truncating the field at degree 50 suppresses the maximum pass residual to 16 mm/s (medians 0.8 to 10.2 mm/s) at a cost of about 0.03 s per pass. Truncation at degree 100 lowers the medians to 0.5 to 1.8 mm/s (largest 11 mm/s, at LRO) but requires four to five times more runtime. Degree 50 is therefore the production setting. The harmonic switch-on radius is set to 10 lunar radii (17,380 km). This keeps eccentric orbits like Blue Ghost 1 (apoapsis at 4.28 lunar radii) entirely within the harmonic field and avoids 2 to 31 km of truncation boundary errors. A 24-hour forward and backward run returns to within 0.1 mm of its start.

Peregrine's reconstruction has no quiet stretch at all. Its unexplained acceleration has a median of 7.6×10^{-5} m/s^2 and a 90th percentile of 1.8×10^{-4} m/s^2. The provider traced the loss of that mission to a helium pressure control valve that failed to seal [42]. The residual shows where that leak appears in the trajectory; the engine does not estimate the leak.

Shadow edges were compared with SPICE's own occultation finder along two days of IM-2's lunar orbit, with the same spheres on both sides. Both found the same 24 shadow passes. The 48 edges differ by a median of 0.07 s and at most 0.10 s, inside the plan's 1 s.

5.4 Launch instants against the flown liftoffs

Each Falcon 9 lunar launch was designed from its pad, NASA's arrival at the Moon and the climb constant of the vehicle's other flights. Table 7 compares the designed liftoff with the published one under three choices of climb direction.

Table 7: Designed minus published liftoff, by the climb direction the design assumes.

Mission	Flown climb azimuth	Due east	Azimuth it flew	Other flight's azimuth
IM-1	88.8°	9.8 min	0.2 min	−15.8 min
IM-2	86.6°	27.4 min	−0.0 min	17.5 min
Blue Ghost 1	110.2°	phasing loops (fig. 4)		

Designed at the azimuth each flight actually climbed, the liftoff lands within 0.2 min of the published one. The designed coast, TLI speed and flight time agree with the flown values within 1.4 min, 1 m/s and 0.02 d. That result uses the flight's own direction, which is not known before launch. Held out, each Nova-C lander designed at the other flight's azimuth misses by 15.8 min and 17.5 min. The plan asked for 10 min, so this criterion is **not met**. The two flown azimuths differ by 2.2°, and each degree moves the instant by about seven minutes. Nothing published predicts which azimuth a flight will take. The planned calendar therefore climbs at the mean azimuth of the vehicle's direct flights and states the larger held-out miss as its margin. For Griffin-1 the designed climb is 87.7°, and every liftoff carries ±18 min.

Designing at the two ends of the pad's allowed climb azimuths gives the earliest and latest liftoff the geometry permits. For IM-1 these lie 105.5 min before and 300.0 min after the flown liftoff, and for IM-2 163.3 min before and 269.3 min after. They are ranges of geometric feasibility, not launch windows: nothing published shows that the vehicle could fly throughout them.

5.5 Phasing loops and the correction budget

Burns were read from Blue Ghost 1's reconstruction by propagating each half hour and comparing its end with the reconstruction. Three burns before departure were found: 22.53, 3.27 and 23.61 m/s, a total of 49.4 m/s. Replayed from the first reconstructed state with these burns, the

six flown apogees and perigees fall within 1.8 min and 0.022 % in radius of the reconstruction. The plan asked for 1 h and 1 %.

The loop design was then run for eleven launch days around the flown one (fig. 4). The flown day needs three loops, as flown, and costs 50.1 m/s. It is the cheapest of the eleven days by 45 m/s. On that day the Sun's pull over each eight-day loop does most of the perigee raising, which a two-body design cannot capture. Designed at the azimuth Blue Ghost 1 actually climbed, 110.2°, the flown day's liftoff lands 0.6 min after the published one, inside the plan's 5 min.

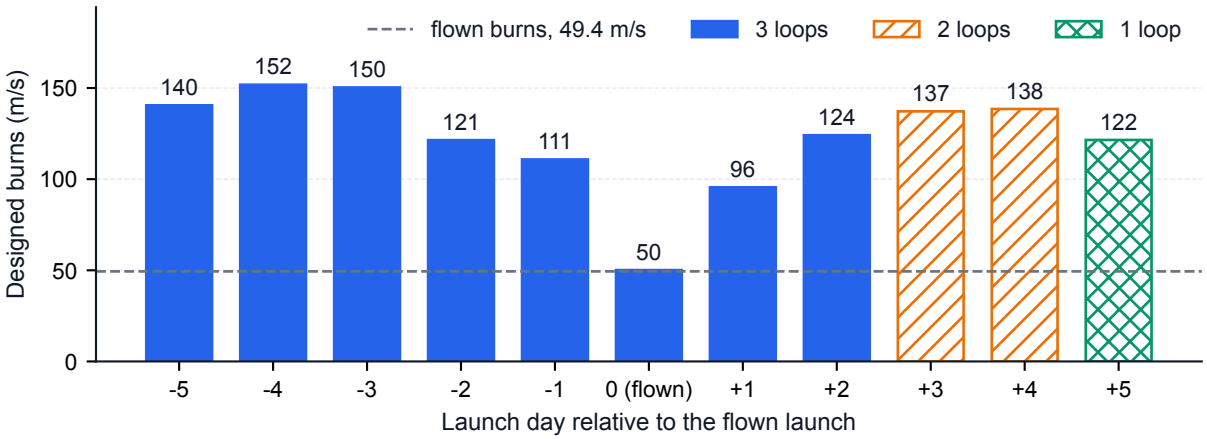


Figure 4: Designed burn total per launch day for Blue Ghost 1 (design climbing due east). The flown day is the cheapest; the dashed line is the total of the three flown burns.

Table 8 gives the correction budget for the three landers under assumed errors and under errors worked out from the published injection accuracy. That accuracy is the one the Falcon 9 user's guide prints for a geosynchronous transfer orbit (Rev 2, October 2015, Table 3-2, 3-sigma: apogee ±500 km, perigee ±10 km, inclination ±0.1°). Only that revision prints an injection accuracy, so it dates from the vehicle of 2015 and is not a figure for Block 5. The linear and Monte Carlo percentiles agree within 7.1 %, satisfying the 10 % acceptance limit. The published accuracy scales the 95th-percentile budget by a factor of 2.8 to 3.0 compared to the assumed errors. Blue Ghost 1's single flown correction of 1.15 m/s lies well inside its budget. IM-2's seven corrections total 24 m/s, falling well within its 95th-percentile envelope of 63.27 m/s. IM-1's reconstruction exhibits no mid-course corrections because its burns occurred during reconstruction data gaps.

Table 8: Total correction budget under assumed errors and published injection accuracy.

Mission	Error model	95th, lin / runs	99th, lin / runs	99th, 95 % interval	Arrival altitude
Blue Ghost 1	Assumed	14.64 / 14.16	19.24 / 18.08	16.52–19.85	156.2 to 160.2 km
	Published	40.78 / 40.63	53.97 / 54.24	50.29–58.52	156.4 to 160.2 km
IM-1	Assumed	20.90 / 21.64	27.43 / 28.50	25.93–30.40	110.6 to 114.5 km
	Published	61.96 / 60.13	81.47 / 77.24	70.85–81.43	110.6 to 114.6 km
IM-2	Assumed	21.29 / 21.45	27.84 / 28.89	26.24–30.24	99.8 to 103.8 km
	Published	62.71 / 63.27	82.40 / 88.66	80.00–94.73	99.7 to 103.9 km

Velocities in m/s. 1,000 seeded Monte Carlo runs compared against 100,000-draw linear covariance propagation.

5.6 Radiation screening

The plan asked for belt fluences within 5 % of SPENVIS. Seven belt passages of the flown trips were uploaded and run in SPENVIS 4.6.14 with the AP-8 MAX and AE-8 MAX maps, IM-2's on 1 October 2026 and the other six on 3 October. A passage is one stretch of a reconstruction inside the belts, sampled each minute. Both sides were integrated over the passage's own sample

times (table 9). Electrons agree within 1.3 % on every passage. Protons are 2.0 to 5.8 % high on every passage, and two passages miss the gate: Blue Ghost 1's second and Peregrine's first. The gate was not widened and the engine was not changed, so the two failures stand.

Table 9: Belt fluence over seven passages: engine `rad-5` against SPENVIS (limit 5 %).

		Protons >10 MeV (1/cm^2)			Electrons >1 MeV (1/cm^2)			
Passage	Samples	SPENVIS	Engine	Diff.	SPENVIS	Engine	Diff.	Gate
IM-2, 1	437	1.083×10^6	1.111×10^6	2.56 %	1.158×10^{10}	1.171×10^{10}	1.09 %	met
Blue Ghost 1, 1	429	3.294×10^5	3.359×10^5	1.97 %	1.410×10^9	1.422×10^9	0.87 %	met
Blue Ghost 1, 2	974	2.114×10^8	2.235×10^8	5.75 %	1.320×10^{10}	1.337×10^{10}	1.27 %	not met
Blue Ghost 1, 3	958	2.797×10^8	2.921×10^8	4.43 %	2.941×10^9	2.972×10^9	1.04 %	met
Blue Ghost 1, 4	950	2.782×10^8	2.907×10^8	4.50 %	3.976×10^9	4.016×10^9	1.01 %	met
Peregrine, 1	437	4.114×10^7	4.337×10^7	5.40 %	1.206×10^{10}	1.211×10^{10}	0.40 %	not met
Peregrine, 2	430	2.272×10^8	2.368×10^8	4.24 %	1.098×10^{10}	1.106×10^{10}	0.72 %	met

The proton excess has one cause, the magnetic shell value L, not the maps. Read at the field strength and L that SPENVIS lists for each sample, the engine's maps give SPENVIS's fluence within 0.7 % on the six passages of 3 October, for both particles. IRBEM turns the field-line integral into L with the dipole moment of the map's own field, 30,875.1 nT for GSFC 12/66 at 1970. McIlwain's definition, on which the maps were built and which SPENVIS follows, uses a fixed 31,165.3 nT. The engine's L for protons is therefore lower by 0.003 to 0.008. On the outer slope of the proton belt, where these passages collect most of their protons, a shell 0.4 % lower reads about 5 % more flux. With L recomputed at the fixed moment, the six proton differences fall between −1.5 % and 1.2 %. This is a diagnosis only: the engine still serves the numbers of table 9.

The first of these runs, on IM-2, exposed the missing drift correction described in section 4. Without it the engine gives 8.55×10^5 protons per square centimetre for that passage, and with it 1.11×10^6. The coefficient is the published one and was not fitted to the SPENVIS output.

A second comparison runs NASA SPDF's own AE8/AP8 code along each whole flown trajectory, at one-minute samples within 15 Earth radii, with solar-maximum maps (table 10). Given the engine's magnetic coordinates, the two codes agree to 0.0 % on every trip, for both particles. Given its own shells, from the International Geomagnetic Reference Field of the flight date, SPDF differs most on IM-2's protons, by 22.7 %. IM-2 crosses the steep lower edge of the inner belt, where a small change of shell changes the flux strongly. The choice of field is a different model configuration, not an error in either code. IM-1's reconstruction starts 242,208 km from Earth, beyond the belts, so its belt numbers are reported as missing with that explicit reason.

Table 10: Belt fluence along whole flown trips: the engine (IRBEM) against NASA SPDF's AE8/AP8 with its own magnetic shells.

		Electrons >1 MeV (1/cm^2)			Protons >10 MeV (1/cm^2)		
Mission	Samples	IRBEM	SPDF	Diff.	IRBEM	SPDF	Diff.
IM-2	437	1.17×10^{10}	1.13×10^{10}	4.0 %	1.11×10^6	1.44×10^6	−22.7 %
Blue Ghost 1	3,311	2.18×10^{10}	2.15×10^{10}	1.5 %	8.07×10^8	7.94×10^8	1.6 %
Peregrine	867	2.32×10^{10}	2.33×10^{10}	−0.4 %	2.80×10^8	2.80×10^8	0.0 %

The cosmic-ray model was checked in absolute terms for June 2009. Its dose in a thin silicon layer in free space is 14.1 cGy per year. Two of CRaTER's detectors gave 18.9 and 16.5 cGy per year, so the model is lower by 26 % and 15 % [26]. Both lie inside the stated ±30 %. Scaled to each trip, the unshielded cosmic-ray dose is (0.21 ± 0.06) mGy per day for IM-1 and (0.17 ± 0.05) mGy per day for Blue Ghost 1. The GOES peaks of the October 1989 and October 2003 events match NOAA's list within 5.5 % and 0.0 %, inside the plan's 10 %.

5.7 Capsule entry against OSIRIS-REx

The OSIRIS-REx capsule's reconstructed trajectory in NAIF's archive ends at the entry interface, 6,503.142 km from the Earth's centre, at 14:41:55 UTC on 24 September 2023. Its state there matches the navigation team's published entry state to the last printed digit: flight path angle −8.184°, heading 66.396° and Earth-relative speed 12.361 km/s [39]. The ballistic coefficient β was built from three published values. The first two are the capsule's mass at entry and the diameter of the Stardust forebody it shares. The third is Stardust's hypersonic axial force coefficient C_A of 1.48 to 1.56 [43]. Atmospheric entry was simulated using NRLMSIS 2.1 [37], parameterized by the day's solar radio flux ($F_{10.7} = 174.1$ sfu) and geomagnetic index ($a_p = 4.0$) from the OMNI2 archive. Table 11 compares the modelled landing with the point measured by the recovery team [40].

NRLMSIS 2.1 was chosen over NRLMSISE-00 [44] and the 1976 U.S. Standard Atmosphere by comparison with the air measured at 30 to 70 km on 24 September 2023. The measurements are of two kinds. The first is the limb profiles of the TIMED satellite's SABER radiometer [45]. The second is the profiles of the Table Mountain Facility lidar for nine nights from 19 to 30 September. The lidar profiles come from the archive of the Network for the Detection of Atmospheric Composition Change (NDACC) [46]. Density decides the choice, not temperature, because density sets how the capsule slows. Between 30 and 70 km, the density of NRLMSIS 2.1 differs from the SABER profiles by 0.6 % and from the lidar profiles by 1.6 %. For NRLMSISE-00 the figures are 3.7 % and 5.0 %. All four are root mean square values over eight 5 km bands. By band, NRLMSISE-00 is warmer than the measurements by 0.6 to 9.5 K (root mean square 4.4 and 5.1 K) and NRLMSIS 2.1 by 0.2 to 5.3 K. NRLMSIS 2.1 has the lower density difference in every cut of the profiles: by latitude, by local solar time and with each lidar night left out.

These measurements are only partly independent of the models, and four cautions apply. First, the selection rule was written after both landing results were known. Second, NRLMSIS 2.0, on which NRLMSIS 2.1 builds, was fitted to SABER temperatures from 2002 to 2016 [47]. Third, the lidar density is scaled to an ancillary profile that its file names as MERRA-2 [20]. MERRA-2 is in the NRLMSIS 2.0 fit up to 55 km. The level of the lidar density is therefore not independent of that fit, but its change with height is. Fourth, the producer marks the SABER files "Unvalidated".

Table 11: Modelled OSIRIS-REx landing against the measured point (limit 10 km).

C_A	β (kg/m^2)	Landing	Miss (km)	To ground (s)	Peak (g)
1.48	64.8	40.3687° N, 113.2861° W	3.9	525	31.9
1.52	63.1	40.3612° N, 113.3169° W	**6.6**	531	32.0
1.56	61.5	40.3539° N, 113.3468° W	9.3	536	32.2

Peak: the largest deceleration on the way down. Modelled with NRLMSIS 2.1 driven by daily space weather indices.

At the nominal drag coefficient ($C_A = 1.52$), the landing point misses by 6.6 km. Over the published C_A range, the miss spans 3.9 to 9.3 km. The plan's acceptance limit of 10 km is therefore **met** across the entire drag range. Under the simplified 1976 U.S. Standard Atmosphere [38], the nominal miss is 9.5 km (6.7 to 12.2 km). Under older NRLMSISE-00, the miss increases to 12.1 km (9.4 to 14.8 km), failing the 10-kilometre limit. The mission team's pre-flight simulation from the identical entry state missed by 8.9 km [40]. Their day-of-entry reconstruction using local weather balloons reached 3.5 km. A seeded Monte Carlo of 200 runs with NRLMSIS 2.1 yields a 99 percent dispersion ellipse of 51.1 km by 21.5 km that holds the measured landing point.

5.8 Launch weather against station observations

No public meteorological tower reports winds at the rule's 162 ft level. Verification was therefore performed at 10 m elevation at Cape Canaveral Space Force Station (KXMR) and Vandenberg Space Force Base (KVBG). The rule's limit of 30 mph at 49 m translates to 23.5 mph (10.52 m/s) at 10 m using a neutral logarithmic wind profile.

Multi-year verification used the NOAA GEFSv12 reforecast archive over 2000 to 2019: every third day, 2,435 days, with five runs at each of two leads. Both archives were downloaded afresh and scored on 1 October 2026. A case counts when the station has a usable observation within 30 minutes of the forecast time. At Vandenberg, the ensemble demonstrates positive skill. With 96 threshold exceedance events in 1,582 cases at 24 h lead time, the Brier skill score is 0.27 (95 % confidence interval 0.17 to 0.38), and the continuous ranked probability score (CRPS) skill is 0.31 (table 12). At 48 h lead time, with 98 events, the Brier skill is 0.18 (0.06 to 0.30). However, Vandenberg does not pass the acceptance gate on reliability. Pooled over both leads, the bin for a forecast share of 1.0 (all five runs over the limit) holds 46 cases. The wind was above the limit in 87 % of them (95 % confidence interval 74 to 94 %). The bin for a share of 0.4 holds 36 cases and observed 58 %. The discrepancies of 0.13 and 0.18 exceed the 0.10 tolerance allowed. At Cape Canaveral, only one event occurred at 24 h and three at 48 h, in 1,473 and 1,492 cases. This is fewer than the 10 events required for a Brier skill calculation. The runs' wind is worse than the station's own record: the CRPS skill is negative (−0.98), and the runs average 5.29 m/s against the station's 3.11 m/s. The likely reason is that the 0.25-degree cell at the Cape is partly sea, where the wind is stronger than at a station inland. Because neither pad passes the acceptance gate, launch weather probability shares remain marked as not checked against observations at both sites. An earlier scoring of 1,583 of these days reached the same two verdicts.

Table 12: GEFSv12 reforecast 10-meter wind verification against station observations.

Station	Lead	Cases	Events	Brier skill (95 % CI)	CRPS skill	Passed gate
Vandenberg (KVBG)	24 h	1,582	96	0.27 (0.17 to 0.38)	0.31	no (reliability)
Vandenberg (KVBG)	48 h	1,589	98	0.18 (0.06 to 0.30)	0.32	no (reliability)
Cape Canaveral (KXMR)	24 h	1,473	1	insufficient events	−0.98	no (bias)
Cape Canaveral (KXMR)	48 h	1,492	3	insufficient events	−0.99	no (bias)

Operational single-model forecasts from the High-Resolution Rapid Refresh (HRRR) were evaluated across 1,826 runs from 2021 to 2025 at leads of 1, 6, 12, and 18 h. HRRR achieves a mean absolute error of 1.0 to 1.4 m/s and a bias of 0.0 to 0.6 m/s. This is 15 to 42 % closer to observed winds than climatology. At 1 h lead at Vandenberg, HRRR achieves a CRPS skill of 0.19 (0.14 to 0.22) and a Brier skill of 0.16 (0.01 to 0.32). At 6 h its Brier skill there is 0.12 and at 12 h −0.01. At 18 h, and at every lead at Cape Canaveral, fewer than ten events occurred and no Brier skill is claimed. An answer reports the counts of the forecast's own lead, never those of all leads pooled, and it gives no verification outside the 1 to 18 h that were scored. A closer wind speed does not show that the calls at the threshold are reliable.

5.9 Lunar orbiters and rover line of sight

Geometric passes for real lunar orbiters (LRO, Danuri, Chandrayaan-2, and CAPSTONE) were validated against JPL Horizons observer ephemerides across landing sites at IM-2, IM-1, and Blue Ghost 1 (table 13). Azimuth and elevation agree within 0.0010° (plan tolerance 0.02°). Rise and set times over a spherical horizon agree within 0.003 s (plan tolerance 2.0 s). Checking LRO line-of-sight vectors against NAIF's definitive reconstruction kernel (`lrorg_2025074_2025166`) gives a maximum angular separation of 0.00018° while above the horizon (plan tolerance 0.01°).

Rover-to-lander line of sight was first evaluated on the 20-meter LOLA digital elevation model for IM-2 (Yaoki rover) and Griffin-1 (FLIP rover). Ray traces were sampled every 5 degrees in

Table 13: Lunar orbiter visibility checks against JPL Horizons and NAIF reconstruction.

Site	Orbiter	Up (min)	Max angle	Max Δel	Max edge Δt
IM-2	LRO	82	0.0002°	0.0002°	1.6 ms
IM-2	Danuri	57	0.0004°	0.0003°	1.8 ms
IM-2	Chandrayaan-2	84	0.0002°	0.0002°	2.0 ms
IM-2	CAPSTONE	766	<0.0001°	<0.0001°	no edges
Blue Ghost 1	LRO	64	0.0010°	0.0006°	3.1 ms
IM-2	NAIF LRO kernel	71	0.00018°	0.00017°	not applicable

azimuth out to radii of 500 and 2,000 m (1,440 cells per test). The running maximum elevation algorithm was compared with an independent brute-force line test sampled every meter. Outside the elevation model's vertical uncertainty band, agreement is 100.00 % at both sites. Within 500 m, the 2 m vertical error creates an angular uncertainty wider than the antenna elevation angle, causing 1,219 of 1,440 cells at IM-2 to be reported as uncertain. The planner serves this as a wide range, not as a certainty it does not have.

With the native terrain, IM-2's 500 m neighbourhood is read from the 4 m stereo model. Its height error of 4.12 m leaves every cell uncertain, so the finer spacing did not give a more decided answer. The 3 m model has no ground at either lander's point and is not used there. Griffin-1 keeps the 20 m model. On LOLA's 5 m model at the rim of Shackleton, 762 and 1,017 of 1,440 cells lie outside the band at 500 and 2,000 m, and all of them agree with the brute-force test.

The brute-force test checks the algorithm against a second implementation by the same authors. An independent reference was added on 1 October 2026: the viewshed routine of the GDAL library,[3] version 3.9.3, on the same raster and the same target points, with lunar curvature and no refraction (table 14). Four cases agree on 99.43 to 100.00 % of the targets outside the band. Griffin-1 at 500 m agrees on 221 of 252, or 87.70 %: the engine reports 31 targets clear that GDAL reports blocked. The cause is not established. The engine does not count ground within two posts of either end as a blocker, and GDAL's scan has no such rule. IM-2's 4 m case cannot be scored, because 520 cells of its raster hold no data. The plan's 99 % is therefore **not met** at one site, and no terrain or threshold was altered to make it pass.

Table 14: Rover line of sight against GDAL's viewshed on the same raster (limit 99 %).

Site	Spacing	Radius	Targets	Agree	Result
IM-2	4 m	500 m			unresolved: cells with no data
IM-2	20 m	2,000 m	779	100.00 %	met
Griffin-1	20 m	500 m	252	87.70 %	not met
Griffin-1	20 m	2,000 m	698	99.43 %	met
Shackleton rim	5 m	500 m	709	100.00 %	met
Shackleton rim	5 m	2,000 m	986	100.00 %	met

5.10 Response times and the compute queue

Table 15 gives response times through the API at commit `43a1815`, with the compute and feeds workers stopped. The run followed three readings of the one-minute load average below 2, taken 20 s apart. A *cold* surface request asks for a window that no earlier request has asked for. It counts only if the response reports a cache miss, and all 30 of each kind did. A *warm* request repeats a window or reads a stored section answer. Each section was read 20 times for each of four missions: IM-1, IM-2, Blue Ghost 1 and Griffin-1.

A stored answer of any section returns within 14.1 ms at the 95th percentile. Of the 11.2 ms of a cold four-numbers request, the positions of the Sun and Earth take 6.7 ms and the two

[3] `https://gdal.org/en/stable/api/gdal_alg.html`

Table 15: Response times through the API, median and 95th percentile.

Request	*N*	Median	p95
Landing: the surface engine			
Horizon mask, 1,440 bearings (precompute)	75	46.7 ms	50.0 ms
Four numbers, cold / warm	30 / 30	11.2 / 0.81 ms	13.8 / 0.98 ms
Timeline, 209 kB, cold / warm	30 / 30	15.3 / 4.01 ms	17.7 / 4.29 ms
Stored section answers, warm			
Six-section summary	80	1.5 ms	4.4 ms
Ready	80	1.7 ms	2.5 ms
Launch	80	4.5 ms	9.7 ms
Launch weather	80	8.1 ms	14.1 ms
Trip	80	9.8 ms	10.8 ms
Contact	80	3.9 ms	4.3 ms
Return	80	2.6 ms	5.5 ms

tracks against the skyline 2.9 ms. Most of a cold request is therefore spent on the ephemeris, not on the terrain.

A trip, launch calendar or contact answer that is not yet stored is computed as a job (section 3). The load test asks for these three sections of all 20 missions in one burst. Extra launch and contact windows bring the burst to 138 requests. It runs against its own copy of the database, with two compute workers on the eight-core machine. It was measured with the backend at `f421298` and was not repeated for this version, whose engines for these three sections are the same. The API answered 43 requests from stored answers and queued 58 jobs. It refused 37 contact requests with status 409 and a reason. The 13 missions concerned have no landing to hear. Their landing spot is not published, the lander was lost before reaching the Moon, or the delivery was cancelled. With all 138 requests in flight at once, the API's median response was 761 ms and its slowest 1.42 s. The two workers emptied the queue in 211.5 s, 16.5 jobs per minute, and were busy for 89 % of that time. No job failed or was retried. At the median a contact job ran for 0.19 s, a launch calendar for 13.3 s and a trip for 55.0 s. The longest wait in the queue was a trip's, 160.7 s. The same burst repeated afterwards found every answer stored. It received 101 answers and the same 37 refusals, at a median of 318 ms per request.

5.11 Tests and accessibility

On the backend at commit `43a1815`, the code linter, strict static type checking of 309 source files and all ten architectural import contracts pass without warnings. The test suite collects 905 tests: 676 unit, 184 integration and 45 golden tests, the golden ones pinning model behaviours to committed fixtures and flown trajectories. Against PostgreSQL, 903 pass and 3 are skipped in 6.8 min. The 680 fast tests need no services and run in 18 s.

On the frontend, static type checks pass, and 292 unit and component tests pass across 25 test files in Vitest. All 61 browser end-to-end tests pass in Chromium in 6.6 min against the running API; where a section is not served yet, they read recorded contract fixtures. One of them counts the WebGL contexts each 3D scene opens and checks that every one is released when the scene goes. Four automated browser tests run the axe accessibility engine against levels A and AA of the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1: 26 desktop routes in both themes, five with every row open in both themes, each settings tab, nine more pages with every row open, and 14 phone routes plus six with every row open. The section tests make the same check at 42 more places, among them open sheets and narrow screens. None finds a serious or critical violation.

6 Limitations

Acceptance tolerances not met. Table 16 lists planned acceptance tolerances alongside measured results. Five items fall outside the plan. First, designing a launch instant with an assumed climb azimuth from another flight misses by 15.8 min and 17.5 min against the planned 10 min tolerance, because launch vehicle ascent profiles are proprietary. Second, the model alone misses IM-2's reconstructed cruise by 4.40 km after 24 hours, against the planned 1 km. The miss would be 1.65 km if the two velocity changes of 0.060 m/s and 0.133 m/s (small burns or venting) had been known in advance. Third, the weather ensemble fails the acceptance gate at both launch ranges. Cape Canaveral exhibits negative CRPS skill (−0.98) and has insufficient events for Brier skill. Vandenberg achieves the required Brier skill (0.27 and 0.18) but fails the reliability threshold (discrepancies of 0.13 and 0.18 against the 0.10 limit). Fourth, belt protons are above SPENVIS by 5.75 % and 5.40 % on two of seven passages, against the planned 5 %. The cause is the dipole moment IRBEM uses for the shell value; the engine was not changed. Fifth, the rover line of sight agrees with GDAL's viewshed on 87.70 % of the targets at Griffin-1 within 500 m, against the planned 99 %, and the cause is not established. Capsule entry with NRLMSIS 2.1 meets the 10 km plan limit (landing within 6.6 km, range 3.9 to 9.3 km), but a rule written after both landing results were known chose that air model. NRLMSISE-00 missed by 12.1 km, with a density above the measured density at 30 to 70 km.

Parts of the plan not built. Commercial lander operators do not publish transmitter power, receiver sensitivity, or antenna gains. Communications modeling therefore evaluates geometric line of sight rather than RF link budgets. No CLPS mission currently returns payloads from the lunar surface to Earth, and planned missions publish no Earth-return trajectory or atmospheric entry state. The Moon-to-Earth return trajectory and capsule recovery site weather are therefore not built. European meteorological ensemble forecasts (ECMWF) are not archived because open data access provides only global grids rather than point extractions. NASA GEOS-FP forecasts and NAVAREA IV maritime hazard broadcasts could not be accessed from the automated feeds worker.

Validity of the references. GMAT, one of the plan's references, was not run. Closed-form tests replace it: two-body motion against Kepler's equation, the J2 nodal drift against its analytic rate, and forward-and-backward runs. SPENVIS and NASA's AE8/AP8 code implement the same belt models as the engine, so agreement shows correct use of the models, not their accuracy. The SPENVIS runs were made by hand and cover solar-maximum maps and two energy thresholds only. NASA's descent reconstructions set the landing instants, so their agreement with those instants is by construction; the independent parts of that check are the landing positions and the Sun and Earth elevations. The four CLPS reconstructions are orbit determination products, not truth, and IM-2's contains an unexplained acceleration.

Carried over from the surface engine. The terrain's vertical error is one value per product, 2 m, 3.5 m or 4 m, not a per-pixel error, and crossing errors are treated as independent. The near-field noise threshold is not part of any margin. The four targets outside 80° S have terrain to 50 km at about 60 m spacing, coarser than the 20 m model used near a polar site. Three of them are the centres of named features, not landing points. A target north of 60° N, or one whose window is not on disk, is still computed on a smooth sphere, and its durations are upper bounds. The server script and its two images were checked by a dry run and by unit tests, and had not been built on a server when this report was written. No model key was configured on the measurement machine, so the agents were not evaluated with a live language model. Their tests use scripted model replies. No user with a screen reader has tested the screens.

7 Conclusion

Table 16: Planned acceptance tolerances and the measured values.

Check	Plan	Measured	Met
Propagation of reconstructions, 24 h	1 km	0.06–0.51 km; IM-2 cruise 4.40 km	partly
Propagation of reconstructions, 72 h	5 km	0.85, 1.08 km	yes
Lunar orbit gravity field per pass	0.05 m/s	16 mm/s (degree 50); degree 0 leaves 0.5–1.6 m/s	yes
LRO in lunar orbit, 24 h	1 km	0.03, 0.07 km	yes
Forward and backward run, 24 h	1 m	5.8 mm	yes
Shadow edges against SPICE	1 s	0.10 s	yes
Liftoff from the flown TLI	2 or 5 min	4 to 15 s	yes
Liftoff designed at the flown azimuth	2 or 5 min	0.0 to 0.6 min	yes
Liftoff designed at the other flight's azimuth	10 min	15.8, 17.5 min	no
Loop replay: apsis time, radius	1 h, 1 %	1.8 min, 0.022 %	yes
Loop design: flown loop count and date	both	3 loops; period holds the date	yes
Correction budget, linear against runs	10 %	7.1 % (published injection accuracy)	yes
Belt fluence against SPENVIS, seven passages	5 %	electrons 0.4 % to 1.3 %; protons 2.0 % to 5.8 %, two passages over	partly
Belt fluence against SPDF's code, same shells	5 %	0.0 % on every trip	yes
Cosmic-ray dose against CRaTER	30 %	−26 %, −15 %	yes
Solar event peaks against NOAA	10 %	5.5 %, 0.0 %	yes
Wind shares, multi-year gate	Brier ≥ 0.1, rel ≤ 0.1	KVBG fails rel (0.13, 0.18); KXMR negative CRPS (−0.98)	no
Capsule landing	10 km	6.6 km (NRLMSIS 2.1, range 3.9–9.3 km; NRLMSISE-00 12.1 km)	yes
Lunar orbiters against Horizons	0.02°, 2.0 s	0.0010°, 0.003 s (NAIF check 0.00018°)	yes
Rover line of sight against a brute-force test	99 %	100.00 % outside uncertain band	yes
Rover line of sight against GDAL	99 %	four cases 99.43 to 100.00 %; Griffin-1 at 500 m 87.70 %; one unresolved	partly
Touchdown against NASA's descent reconstructions (added)	1 s, 100 m, 0.01°	within 1 s; 0.3 to 79.2 m; 0.00003°	yes
GMAT comparison	run	not run	no

POLAR WINDOW follows a CLPS delivery across six operational sections, from ground readiness to post-flight recovery. Every computed number provides provenance, freshness, and explicit uncertain bounds or missing reasons. The system produces no arbitrary go/no-go verdicts or composite scores. Physical models were validated against the public record of flown missions, including NASA reconstructions of four CLPS trajectories, published liftoffs, and satellite observations. Touchdown instants and positions agree with NASA's descent reconstructions, and every mission target that a terrain model covers now has a real skyline. Most acceptance checks satisfy the planned tolerances. Five measured results fall outside the plan: the liftoff designed at another flight's azimuth, the IM-2 cruise position error, the wind check at both launch pads, the belt protons on two of seven passages against SPENVIS, and the rover line of sight against GDAL at one site. The GMAT comparison was not run. The capsule entry model meets its tolerance. Planned relays, lunar orbiters, and rover line of sight provide transparent communication visibility. RF link budgets and the Moon-to-Earth return trajectory remain unbuilt because required engineering parameters are not public. The system serves as a screening and comparison tool, designed to help mission teams evaluate trade-offs before committing to specialized analysis pipelines.

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A Reproducing the numbers

Each table and figure comes from one command, run from the repository root with the services and data described in the runbook. Targets named `make` are in the repository. Scripts named by file are in `docs/report/scripts/` and run from `backend/` with `uv run python ../docs/report/scripts/`*`name`*; most read the running API. The data behind the figures and tables 5 and 15 are in its `data/` folder.

Table 17: Where each result comes from.

Result	Command
Tables 6 to 8	`make validate-trip`
Figure 4	`make validate-trip`, drawn by `make_fig_loops.py`
Shadow edges against SPICE	`test_eclipse_vs_spice.py`, printed by `eclipse_check.py`
Table 12 and multi-year checks	`python -m app.validation.validate_weather gefs` and `hrrr`; the checked scores are in `docs/validation-evidence/`
Table 10 and the cosmic-ray and event checks	`make validate-radiation`
Table 9	SPENVIS by hand, then `python -m app.validation.compare_spenvis` (steps in `docs/spenvis-manual-validation.md`)
Table 3	`make validate-landing`
Table 4	the stored skylines, read through `GET /sites/{id}/horizon`
Table 11 and the footprint	`make validate-capsule`
Table 13	`make validate-orbiters`
Rover line of sight; table 14	`make validate-viewshed`; `make validate-viewshed-gdal`
Table 1	`uv run polar-data list` and the sizes of the folders under `data/`
Table 5, fig. 3	`export_data.py` and `make_figure.py`
Landing hindcast	`test_hindcast.py`; `hindcast_surface.py`
Table 15	`measure_timing.py` and `sections.py --timing`
The compute queue	`make load-compute`
Figure 2	`npm run screens` (`frontend/scripts/screens.ts`), then `make_fig_screens.py`
Test counts	`make lint`, `make test-fast`, `npx vitest run`, `npx playwright test`